



To whom it may concern

The Social Cyber Institute would like to record its appreciation for the volunteer work of M. Neil Bouchard in support of our research and publications work during his completion of a Master's degree in International Relations at the University of Queensland.

Neil signed on for 3 days per week (21 hours) over three months (1 April to 20 June 2026) to support the Institute at a critical time in its development.

In that time, Neil produced a high-quality Discussion Paper (8,000 words) on France and AI sovereignty for publication in the Discussion Paper series of the Institute. The paper was highly evaluated by our Chairman, one of Australia's most eminent social scientists, Professor Glenn Withers. He wrote: "This is an absolutely excellent paper. The content is very insightful and has implications for Carney's third way, including Australia." That is an assessment I concur with, having worked with Neil as mentor in his development of the paper.

I should note that Neil voluntarily continued beyond his nominal completion date to continue to revise the paper. He was the only one of six volunteers taken on at the same time to undertake or complete a full paper of this kind.

Neil consistently demonstrated high flexibility and an excellent aptitude for international policy analysis. It was a great pleasure working with Neil on these important tasks for the Institute.

I can highly recommend Neil for the six-month European Commission traineeship. I would also gladly serve as a referee for Neil if any prospective employer would like additional referee comments.

A handwritten signature in blue ink that reads "G. D. Austin". The signature is fluid and cursive, with a long horizontal stroke extending from the end.

Professor Greg Austin
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